The Rich Report

U.S. Economics News:

- **Electricity Demand:** The U.S. set a record with 4.43 thousand TWh of electricity generation in 2025, and projections call for an additional 400 TWh by 2030 — equivalent to roughly 45 gigawatts of constant 24/7 power. Data centers are the primary driver of this surge, representing the steepest demand increase the country has seen in decades and creating urgent questions about generation capacity and grid infrastructure.[3]
- **Capacity Gap:** Nuclear operates at a 91% capacity factor compared to 24% for solar and 34% for wind, which is why nuclear accounts for 18% of total U.S. electricity generation despite being only 8% of installed capacity. As data center demand requires reliable baseload power around the clock, this distinction between nameplate capacity and actual output becomes critical for planning the next generation of energy infrastructure.[3]
- **Rate Reversal:** At the start of 2026, fed funds futures implied more than two rate cuts ahead. That expectation has completely reversed, with markets now pricing in a possible rate increase by year-end. The shift is driven by surging energy prices putting upward pressure on CPI and the geopolitical uncertainty entering the fourth week of the war with Iran, which has no clear timeline for resolution.[3]
- **K-Shaped Stress:** The so-called K-shaped economy may be losing its upper leg of support. The top 20% of earners account for 63% of total U.S. spending, fueled by stock and home price gains, but with the S&P 500 back to where it was eight months ago, wealth-effect spending could stall. GDP grew just 2.0% in 2025, and the Atlanta Fed projects the same pace for Q1 2026, with more downside risk than upside given an oversized federal government that continues to crowd out private investment.[3]

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Digital Assets News:

- **Clarity Act Yield Ban:** The latest Clarity Act draft would bar rewards on passive stablecoin balances and ban anything "economically equivalent to interest," threatening a key incentive that has fueled USDC adoption and drawing criticism from crypto insiders.[5]
- **Circle Plunge:** Circle shares fell 20% and Coinbase dropped about 10% after the restrictive Clarity Act language emerged, snapping Circle's 170% rally since early February.[5]
- **Mining Crisis:** The average public miner spent roughly $80,000 to produce one bitcoin last quarter while BTC trades near $70,000, prompting the industry to pivot to AI with over $70 billion in contracts signed and miners liquidating bitcoin treasuries to fund the transition.[5]

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Geopolitics News:

- **China:** Two Chinese container ships attempted to exit the Strait of Hormuz after Iran promised safe passage for "friendly nations" but turned back, demonstrating that safe transit still cannot be guaranteed despite Tehran's assurances.[1]
- **Germany:** Inflation jumped to 2.8% in March from 2.0% in February, driven by energy prices rising 7.2% year-over-year — the first energy price increase since December 2023 — as the Iran war pushes costs well above the ECB's 2% target.[1]
- **Iran:** The IRGC naval commander who led the Strait of Hormuz blockade, Alireza Tangsiri, was killed in an Israeli airstrike, though the U.S. can only confirm about a third of Iran's missile arsenal has been destroyed, with another third likely damaged or buried in tunnels.[1]
- **Iran:** Tehran has reportedly begun charging up to $2 million per ship for "safe passage" through the Hormuz Strait, with over 3,200 vessels stranded, effectively turning the critical global chokepoint into a toll booth that one Iranian lawmaker framed as covering "war costs."[1]
- **Russia:** At least 40% of Russia's oil export capacity — roughly 2 million barrels per day — has been halted following Ukrainian drone attacks on all three major western export ports (Novorossiysk, Primorsk, Ust-Luga) and the disruption of the Druzhba pipeline, the most severe oil supply disruption in Russia's modern history.[1]
- **United Kingdom:** PM Starmer authorized the military to board and detain Russian shadow fleet tankers in British waters, joining France, Belgium, and Sweden in escalating efforts to disrupt Moscow's sanctions-evasion oil exports as Putin benefits from surging Iran-war oil prices.[1]
- **United States:** A U.S. court suspended Pentagon sanctions against Anthropic, with a San Francisco judge finding the government appeared to be punishing the AI company for criticizing the administration, likely violating free speech protections.[1]
- **United States:** The Senate approved funding for TSA and most of Homeland Security after a 42-day stalemate, but excluded immigration enforcement funding, with Trump pledging to immediately pay TSA agents amid airport chaos.[1]
- **Yemen:** The Houthis entered the Iran war, raising the risk of renewed attacks on the Bab al-Mandab Strait — a second critical shipping chokepoint — after Iran already effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz, which would deepen the global oil and trade crisis.[1]

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The Good News:

- **AI Drug Discovery:** Insilico Medicine's AI-identified compound rentosertib performed well in phase 2 clinical trials for idiopathic pulmonary fibrosis and is advancing to phase 3, potentially becoming the first true AI-discovered medicine to reach approval — created on an accelerated timeline and at a fraction of traditional drug discovery costs.[2]
- **EV Fast Charging:** BYD is unveiling a 1,500kW drive-through charging system in Paris that can boost its Denza Z9GT from 10% to 70% battery in just five minutes and fully charge in nine minutes, potentially eliminating one of the last major obstacles to widespread EV adoption.[2]
- **GLP-1 Muscle Safety:** A meta-analysis of 20 randomized controlled trials found that lean mass loss from GLP-1 drugs like semaglutide and tirzepatide is proportionally comparable to traditional lifestyle interventions alone, countering concerns that the medications cause disproportionate muscle wasting — while adding resistance training showed the best muscle-preservation profile.[2]

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Dividend Portfolio News:

- **ADI:** Analog Devices was upgraded at Aretes and named a stock to watch alongside reports of chip price hikes from AMD and Intel, with Cantor noting analog chips may still outperform even as the broader semiconductor sector faces Iran-war-driven selling pressure.[4]
- **LMT:** Lockheed Martin secured a $478 million Navy contract, tested a containerized missile launcher and rapid-launch capabilities with Firefly for the Space Force, and saw Pentagon deals to boost key missile production as the U.S. considers diverting Ukraine-bound weapons to the Middle East.[4]
- **PCAR:** PACCAR is positioned to benefit as Texas becomes the primary test track for U.S. autonomous truck development, with multiple companies piloting self-driving commercial vehicles on the state's highway corridors.[4]
- **QCOM:** Goldman Sachs initiated Qualcomm at Neutral, citing market diversification efforts offset by smartphone share losses, while Apple's new C1X modem and Intel/AMD supply constraints affecting PC and server makers added cross-currents for the chipmaker.[4]
- **SYK:** Stryker rebounded after restoring most manufacturing activity following a cyberattack that had disrupted operations, signaling the medical device maker contained the incident without lasting production impact.[4]
- **TEL:** TE Connectivity reached a settlement with Credo over their active electrical cable technology dispute, resolving a legal overhang that had created uncertainty around the company's high-speed connectivity product line.[4]
- **VLO:** Valero dealt with fires at both its Port Arthur and Texas City refineries — neither deemed intentional — while the EPA issued an E15 gasoline waiver and boosted biofuel blending quotas to ease pump prices, and Russia's ban on gasoline exports starting April 1 could tighten global refined product supply.[4]

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Growth Portfolio News

- **AMD:** Advanced Micro Devices led chip stocks higher mid-week on reports of price hikes alongside Intel, but gave back gains as AI and semiconductor stocks sank on continued Iran war pressure, with Arm unveiling a data center CPU aimed at taking market share from both AMD and Intel.[4]
- **COIN:** Coinbase partnered with Better Home & Finance to launch crypto-backed mortgages, while facing headwinds from the Clarity Act's stablecoin yield restrictions that could impact its USDC revenue-sharing model with Circle, and crypto stocks were among the week's top losers.[4]
- **CVX:** Chevron warned California risks a fuel crisis unless the Middle East war eases, extended its stock winning streak to seven sessions, and faces weeks of repairs at its Wheatstone LNG facility in Australia after Cyclone Narelle — further tightening global LNG supply already strained by the Hormuz disruption.[4]
- **HOOD:** Robinhood expanded its credit facility to $3.25 billion and approved a $1.5 billion share buyback program, signaling management confidence even as financial stocks broadly underperform and market volatility weighs on trading sentiment.[4]
- **OKE:** ONEOK was upgraded at Wells Fargo alongside Enterprise Products, with analysts seeing a war-driven boost for U.S. LPG exporters as Strait of Hormuz disruptions redirect global energy trade flows and send plastics prices soaring.[4]
- **PDD:** PDD Holdings reported Q4 revenue of $17.72 billion, missing estimates by $390 million, with non-GAAP earnings of $2.53 per share missing by $0.52 despite 12% revenue growth driven by marketing and transaction volume — signaling slowing momentum in its e-commerce business.[4]
- **TSM:** Taiwan Semiconductor was flagged as a stock to watch as a Broadcom executive said TSMC is reaching capacity limits, while Apple added suppliers to its American Manufacturing Program and insider trading activity drew attention among large-cap chip names.[4]

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Summary:

In regard to the United States Economy, electricity demand is surging to levels not seen in decades, with the U.S. setting a generation record in 2025 and projections calling for an additional 400 terawatt-hours by 2030. Meanwhile, interest rate expectations have flipped dramatically, with markets now pricing in a possible Fed rate hike by year-end after starting 2026 expecting multiple cuts. Adding to concerns, the K-shaped economy may be losing support on both ends, with the wealth effect fading as the S&P 500 stalls and GDP growth stuck.

In the world of digital assets, the Clarity Act's latest draft sent shockwaves through the stablecoin ecosystem by banning rewards on passive balances and anything "economically equivalent to interest," hammering Circle shares by 20% and Coinbase by 10% in a single session. Bitcoin mining economics have broken down as well, with the average public miner spending roughly $80,000 to produce one bitcoin while it trades near $70,000.

Recently around the globe, the Iran war entered its fifth week with the Houthis joining the conflict, raising the specter of a second shipping chokepoint closure at the Bab al-Mandab Strait alongside the already-shuttered Strait of Hormuz, where Tehran has begun charging vessels up to $2 million for safe passage. The killing of Iran's IRGC naval commander by Israel underscored the campaign's intensity, though the U.S. can only confirm a third of Iran's missile arsenal destroyed. Ukraine's intensified drone strikes halted 40% of Russia's oil export capacity, prompting the UK to authorize boarding Russian shadow fleet tankers.

For the good news, artificial intelligence achieved a milestone in drug discovery as Insilico Medicine's AI-identified compound rentosertib advanced to phase 3 clinical trials for pulmonary fibrosis, potentially becoming the first true AI-discovered medicine to reach approval on an accelerated timeline. BYD is set to unveil a 1,500-kilowatt charging system capable of boosting an EV battery from 10% to 70% in just five minutes. And a meta-analysis found that GLP-1 medications cause proportionally similar lean mass loss to traditional lifestyle interventions.

In the news for the dividend portfolio, Lockheed Martin continued stacking contracts with a $478 million Navy deal and Pentagon agreements to boost missile production, while Analog Devices earned an upgrade at Aretes amid expectations of an analog chip rebound. Stryker rebounded after containing a cyberattack with minimal lasting production impact, TE Connectivity resolved its legal dispute with Credo, and Valero navigated refinery fires at two Texas facilities as the EPA expanded biofuel blending quotas to ease pump prices. And, PACCAR stands to benefit from Texas emerging as the hub for autonomous truck development.

And, for the growth portfolio, Chevron warned California faces a fuel crisis if the Middle East war continues. PDD Holdings disappointed with a $390 million revenue miss and earnings $0.52 below estimates despite 12% growth, while TSMC is reportedly reaching capacity limits. And, Coinbase launched crypto-backed mortgages but faces Clarity Act headwinds.

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